The *haredim* were a tiny minority, too small to impose their religious views on the general public. The draft exemption only applied to 400 young men. For Ben-Gurion, this seemed a low price to pay for Jewish unity and a sturdy coalition. He also believed the whole debate would soon be irrelevant. Like many of his contemporaries, he saw the ultra-Orthodox community as an oddity, a dusty curio from the centuries of Jewish exile. Freed from the *shtetl*, they would soon adopt a new Hebrew identity and become Israeli.

Peres was a longtime friend of Israel's founder, and helped him negotiate the army exemption. He wrote a biography of Ben-Gurion in 2011 with the late David Landau, *The Economist*'s longtime Jerusalem correspondent. At one point, in a dialogue between the authors, Landau asked Peres whether Ben-Gurion thought "the number of traditionally observant Jews would decline." Peres, ever the politician, tried to dodge the question, but his answer left little doubt: Ben-Gurion indeed thought that the last adherents of European Orthodoxy would wither on the vine. "We believed that the Diasporic version of Judaism was transient," Peres said. "Ben-Gurion's objection was not to the religion but to the organized 'church'. He maintained that pristine Judaism had no hierarchy, no God's deputy, no bishops… but Ben-Gurion decided not to fight this ideological battle."[11]

In 1952, Ben-Gurion paid a visit to the home of Avraham Yeshaya Karelitz, a *haredi* religious leader better known as the "Chazon Ish" ("Vision of Man"). The prime minister wanted to discuss a program of national service for religious women, as an alternative to conscription. Much of the ultra-Orthodox community was horrified by the proposal. Karelitz, however, was an authority on reconciling Jewish law with the demands of a modern state. He came up with a *halakhic* solution that allowed observant dairy farmers to milk their cows on Shabbat, without which they would have quickly gone out of business. The prime minister thought he was the best man to approach about the national-service bill.

The meeting didn't go well. At the time, neither man said much about their conversation, so it became the subject of extensive speculation in the *haredi* press. One columnist reported that the near-sighted *rebbe* had removed his trademark round glasses, so he wouldn't have to "look in the villain's face."

Ben-Gurion recorded only a few details in his personal diary. Aside from the two interlocutors, however, a third man was present at the meeting: